

The Gradualist Turn

Sarah's diagnosis is right: comprehensive makeover proposals are unreadable to a board in emotional crisis, we should study the living rather than the dying, and David's one-pathway instinct is the way in. The one thing worth changing is the pace. **An open-ended research phase has no forcing function, so it does not end — it just gets quieter.** Forty-five days instead. Not a pause before the work. A sprint that produces the work.

THE FINDING THAT MAKES GRADUALISM OPERATIONAL

Sarah's sharpest point was that nobody has authority to approve a radical reconstruction, and nobody has authority to hire us. True — for the big version. But a college's own delegation-of-authority policy draws a hard line between **selling** property and **leasing** it. Tufts caps its VP for Finance at \$1M on a sale and sets no dollar cap on space leases. Cornell's CFO can execute leases to \$2M alone. **A proposal that leases rather than sells, puts no accredited program in the space, and leaves the mission alone can often be signed by one person.**

No board vote.

Property lease or sale appears nowhere in 34 CFR 602.22, and is not a reportable category for SACSCOC, HLC or MSCHE. Only NECHE requires a filing.

WHAT EXISTS ON OCTOBER 1 THAT DOES NOT EXIST TODAY

01

The Halfway Files

Twenty verified cases of colleges that stayed colleges and added real non-tuition revenue. Named, sourced, priced where the numbers are public. Twelve are already confirmed.

02

Two One-Door Proposals

Real schools, real regions, one pathway each, with the funding program already named and the approval path mapped. Not pitches. Finished documents.

03

A site that matches

Copy blocks and a rebuilt homepage, already drafted. The current site is built for a school that knows it is dying — the wrong front door under this strategy.

THREE WORKSTREAMS, RUNNING AT ONCE

WORKSTREAM A — SARAH Evangelism

- 1 Everyone: **three conversations a week**, in person or by phone. One question — *do you know a college that found new money without closing anything?*
- 2 One shared doc, five lines each. **The flinches are data.**
- 3 Jeff: two posts a week. Publishing dated and bylined is how you answer scoop risk.

WORKSTREAM B — THE METHOD The Halfway Scan

- 1 **Screen.** IPEDS revenue mix; a step change in "other revenue" is the best free flag.
- 2 **Confirm.** Form 990 Schedule R for the real-estate LLCs; Schedule K for private business use.
- 3 **Date it.** EMMA by *obligor*, not issuer — bond filings say what was built.
- 4 **Local trail.** Exempt-to-taxable parcel flips; planning agendas run 6–24 months ahead of everything.
- 5 **Call.** 8–12 per case. Rent, escalators, who carried the risk, the board fight — none of it is public. **This is the moat.**

WORKSTREAM C — THE METHOD The One-Door Proposal

- 1 **Start with the region**, not the campus. CEDS priority list, OEWS location quotient, CHAS cost burden, HRSA shortage scores.
- 2 **Match need to an asset you already have.** Propose building nothing.
- 3 **Find the money first.** State workforce capital, EDA, USDA, CDBG, LIHTC, NMTC. The college never writes a check.
- 4 **Structure it so nobody has to be brave.** Lease plus MOU plus grant application — all officer-level.
- 5 **Twenty to thirty pages**, and deliver it to one person, in person.

THE FORTY-FIVE DAYS

AUG 18 – SEPT 1 · BUILD THE MACHINE

Run the screen. Stand up the alert stack and the conversation log. Ship the website changes. Pick the two proposal targets and pull their regional data.

SEPT 1 – SEPT 20 · FILL THE FILES

Get to twenty verified cases and make the calls. On both targets: bylaws, delegation policy, accreditor posture, and the specific funding program with its calendar.

SEPT 20 – OCT 1 · WRITE

Draft both proposals. Publish the first two case files under Jeff's byline. Team read-through, then decide who each proposal goes to and who delivers it.

SARAH'S TWO DOWNSIDES, ANSWERED

"Others in this space may scoop us."

Compression is half the hedge; publishing is the other half. A case study out in September under Jeff's byline is a claim staked. Sitting on twenty cases until we feel ready is the actual exposure.

"We might not make any money, maybe indefinitely."

The proposal is designed so the college never pays. And the fastest first check here is a municipal feasibility study, not a college engagement — Ashland, Wisconsin hired a consultant for \$7,500 to study a closed campus. Public buyers, public budgets, no confidentiality friction. **Gradualism does not have to mean unpaid.**